



SHOCK OF THE SOUTH: The Karnataka verdict is a blow to Sonia and Manmohan, who have been accumulating the wreckage of erstwhile citadels since 2004

looks unstoppable. With Battlefield 2009 a few months—and five Assembly elections—away, every victory carries a big message—and a bigger challenge. BJP has been counting victories since the catastrophe of 2004; the Congress has been accumulating the wreckage of erstwhile citadels since the glory of 2004.

Now, with the fall of Karnataka to the Yeddy mystique, the colour of political India is changing: as the saffron states multiply, white and green shrink. *Pehle paanch pradesh phir poora desh* (First let's rule the five states and then the country.) That was the most popular BJP slogan in the 1990s; with the party then in power in the states of Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh and Delhi, the slogan would become a reality—and mark the first right turn in Indian politics.

The slogan is worthy of a grand revival, though it's more than *paanch* today. Apart from Karnataka, the party is in power in Himachal Pradesh, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh and shares power in Punjab, Orissa, Bihar and a couple of states in the North-East. The statistics magnify the enormity of the public's disenchantment with the UPA and the vigour with which BJP has been tapping it. The Congress has lost 12 Assembly elections in four years, and BJP has dislodged the Congress in four states (Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Karnataka and Punjab), retaining its control on Gujarat.

So let it be on record: BJP is the number one party, and the Congress has every reason to be scared. Very scared. And where does the right gets its zing from? BJP, after an initial bout of de-

featism, has realised the power of powerlessness. Its prime ministerial candidate L.K. Advani, fully acknowledging the uses of adversity, carries the bad news across the country in a newfound youthfulness at 80. The bad news of India being saddled with its least powerful prime minister so far.

If the prime minister-in-waiting is in the arena at full throttle, others (in BJP, unlike in the Congress, there is the Leader and there are the leaders) too are at the peak of their fighting spirit. Gujarat Chief Minister and the poster boy of Hindu machismo Narendra Modi was the star campaigner in Karnataka. At the 45 election rallies he addressed, always uttering the first words in crowd-pleasing Kannada, the theme was vintage Modi: development plus terrorism. They loved it, and the distance between Ahmedabad and

THE KARNATAKA VERDICT. ADD YEDDY TO MODI AND THE COMBINATION COULD BE QUITE HEADY.